

IE06

Agriculture: Development, Reforms and Policy

2-3 questions a paper across Indian and Rajasthan economy, and the scheme block overlaps heavily with current affairs. Atal Bhujal Yojana was asked in 2021 AND 2023, MSP crops in 2023, NFSA in 2018, PM-KISAN in 2021. Schemes with a Rajasthan link - Soil Health Card launched at Suratgarh, Atal Bhujal covering Rajasthan - are doubly likely.

The sector that supports close to half the workforce but contributes about a sixth of value added. RPSC does not ask you to debate farm policy - it asks which State was declared fully organic, how many crops get MSP, how many States run Atal Bhujal Yojana, and who chaired the Doubling Farmers' Income Committee. Scheme names, years and numbers carry the marks.

Indian Agriculture

Land reforms

- Abolition of intermediaries
- Tenancy reform - Operation Barga
- Ceiling on holdings
- Consolidation - Punjab and Haryana
- Bhoodan 1951, Pochampally

Food security

- NFSA 2013 - 75% rural, 50% urban
- 5 kg per person; AAY 35 kg per family
- Eldest woman is head of household
- PDS through Fair Price Shops

Allied

- White Revolution - Operation Flood 1970
- Blue Revolution - PMMSY 2020
- Rashtriya Gokul Mission 2014
- Largest producer of milk and pulses

Green Revolution

- IADP 1960-61, Thanjavur
- HYVP 1966-67
- Wheat Lerma Rojo 64A, Sonora 64; rice IR-8
- M.S. Swaminathan; Borlaug, Nobel 1970

Marketing

- APMC; Model Acts 2003, 2017, 2018
- eNAM 14 April 2016, run by SFAC
- Farm laws 2020, repealed 2021

Prices and procurement

- CACP 1965, advisory only
- MSP for 22 crops, FRP for sugarcane
- A2, A2+FL, C2 cost concepts
- FCI 1965; DCP since 1997-98

Schemes

- PM-KISAN Rs 6,000 in 3 instalments
- PMFBY 2016 - 2 / 1.5 / 5 per cent premium
- Soil Health Card 2015, Suratgarh
- PMKSY, Atal Bhujal, PKVY, 10,000 FPOs

Where agriculture sits in the economy

Start with the imbalance that defines the sector. Agriculture and allied activities contribute roughly a sixth of gross value added but support close to half of all workers. That gap - small share of output, large share of employment - is why farm incomes lag, and it is why almost every policy in this chapter exists. Learn the two area terms too: gross cropped area counts a field twice if it is sown twice, net sown area counts it once, and cropping intensity is the ratio of the two.

- Average operational holding, Agriculture Census 2015-16: 1.08 hectares.
- Small and marginal holdings - below 2 hectares - are 86.2 per cent of all holdings and operate about 47 per cent of the area.
- $\text{Cropping intensity} = (\text{Gross cropped area} / \text{Net sown area}) \times 100$. Above 100 means more than one crop a year on the same land.
- Do not confuse cropping intensity, which is a ratio of areas, with cropping pattern, which is the mix of crops grown.
- ICAR, the apex research body, was set up on 16 July 1929 on the recommendation of the Royal Commission on Agriculture.

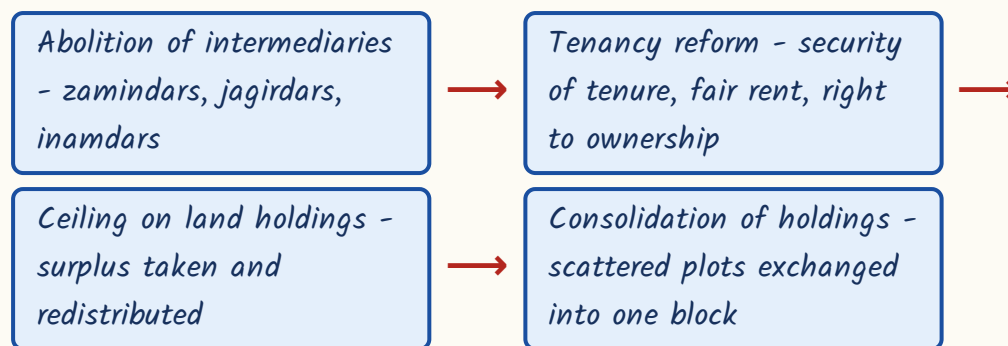
CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: the Economic Survey 2025-26 put foodgrain production at 3,577.3 lakh metric tonnes in agriculture year 2024-25, up 254.3 LMT over the previous year, and horticulture production at 362.08 million tonnes - horticulture output now exceeds foodgrain output in tonnage, and horticulture is about 33 per cent of agricultural GVA. Agriculture GVA is estimated to grow 3.1 per cent in FY26, with livestock and fisheries at 5-6 per cent. More than Rs 4.09 lakh crore has been released under PM-KISAN since inception.

Land reforms - the four pillars

At independence the man who tilled the land usually did not own it. Land reform was the attempt to change that, and it had four components pursued roughly in this order. Learn the order - it is a classic sequencing question - and learn which pillar succeeded and which failed.

The four pillars of land reform, in the order attempted



- Abolition of intermediaries was the most successful pillar - it brought cultivators into direct contact with the State.
- Bihar was the first State to enact a zamindari abolition law, in 1950.
- The challenge to it, the Kameshwar Singh case, led to the First Constitutional Amendment, 1951 and the creation of the Ninth Schedule.
- Tenancy reform had three legs - security of tenure, regulation of rent, and conferment of ownership on the tenant.
- Operation Barga in West Bengal, from 1978, registered sharecroppers (bargadars) and is the most successful tenancy reform in India.
- Consolidation of holdings succeeded mainly in Punjab and Haryana; it barely moved in eastern India.
- Ceiling laws were widely evaded through benami transfers and family partitions, so this pillar redistributed the least land.
- Bhoodan was started by Vinoba Bhave on 18 April 1951 at Pochampally, then in Andhra Pradesh, now in Telangana; Gramdan began at Mangroth, Uttar Pradesh, in 1952.

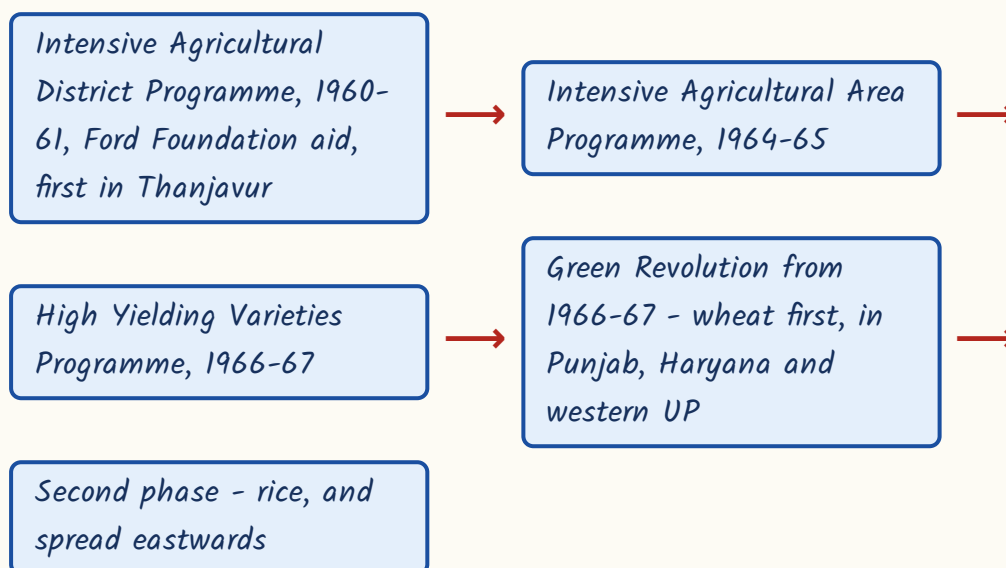
YAAD RAKHO

Remember the pillar order as A-T-C-C: Abolition, Tenancy, Ceiling, Consolidation. And fix the two proper nouns that go with the first two - Bihar 1950 for abolition, Operation Barga 1978 for tenancy.

The Green Revolution and its critique

By the mid-1960s India was importing wheat under PL-480 and living, as the phrase went, ship to mouth. The Green Revolution was the technology package that ended that dependence - high yielding variety seeds, assured irrigation, chemical fertiliser, pesticides and a guaranteed price, all applied together on the best-endowed land. Note that MSP, the CACP and the FCI all date from 1965, just before it: the price guarantee was built in deliberately, because farmers would not adopt a costly package without an assured buyer.

The build-up to the Green Revolution



Green Revolution - the names and seeds that get asked

Item	Detail
Wheat varieties	Lerma Rojo 64A and Sonora 64, from CIMMYT, Mexico

Item	Detail
Rice variety	IR-8, from IRRI, the Philippines
Father of India's Green Revolution	M.S. Swaminathan
Global figure	Norman Borlaug - Nobel Peace Prize, 1970
First programme	IADP 1960-61, launched in Thanjavur district
Mnemonic	Wheat from Mexico (CIMMYT), rice from the Philippines (IRRI)

- Regionally lopsided - Punjab, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh gained; eastern and rain-fed India was left out.
- Crop-lopsided - wheat gained most, then rice; pulses and coarse cereals stagnated, and India still imports pulses and edible oil.
- Class-lopsided - it favoured larger farmers who could afford tube wells, fertiliser and machinery.
- Ecological cost - falling water tables, soil salinity, loss of soil organic carbon, nitrogen run-off, stubble burning.
- Loss of agro-biodiversity, as thousands of local varieties were displaced by a handful of HYVs.
- The policy answer today is diversification, natural farming, micro-irrigation and soil testing - which is why those schemes exist.

Revolutions by colour - a guaranteed matching question

Revolution	Sector	Key link
Green	Foodgrains	M.S. Swaminathan, 1966-67
White	Milk	Operation Flood 1970, NDDB, Verghese Kurien
Yellow	Oilseeds	Technology Mission on Oilseeds, 1986
Blue	Fisheries	PMMSY, September 2020
Golden	Horticulture and honey	-
Silver	Eggs and poultry	-
Grey	Fertilisers	-

Revolution	Sector	Key link
Golden Fibre	Jute	-

Agricultural credit

Credit is the quiet half of agricultural policy. A farmer needs money before the crop and receives money after it, and the gap between the two is where the moneylender used to sit. Institutional credit was built to close that gap.

- NABARD was established on 12 July 1982 on the recommendation of the CRAFTCARD Committee under B. Sivaraman. Headquarters: Mumbai.
- NABARD is the apex refinancing institution for agriculture and rural development - it lends to banks, not usually to farmers directly.
- The Kisan Credit Card was introduced in 1998-99 on the recommendation of the R.V. Gupta Committee.
- KCC now covers crop loans, allied activities including dairy and fisheries, and consumption needs.
- Priority sector lending: overall target 40 per cent of Adjusted Net Bank Credit.
- Within that, agriculture gets 18 per cent, and 10 percentage points of it are earmarked for small and marginal farmers.
- Short-term crop loans carry an effective 4 per cent interest on prompt repayment - 7 per cent nominal minus a 3 per cent incentive.
- Do not attach R.V. Gupta to NABARD - Gupta belongs to the Kisan Credit Card, and Sivaraman to NABARD.

MSP, the CACP and the cost concepts

MSP is a floor price announced before the sowing season. It is a promise that if the market price collapses, government agencies will buy at the announced rate. Two things must be clear - who recommends it and who decides it. The Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices recommends; the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs approves. CACP was set up in January 1965 as the Agricultural Prices Commission and renamed in 1985, and it is an advisory attached office of the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare.

- MSP is NOT legally enforceable - no farmer can sue for it. That was the core demand in the farmers' protests.
- Sugarcane is the exception: it gets a Fair and Remunerative Price under the Sugarcane (Control) Order, 1966, and the FRP IS legally binding on mills.
- A_2 = all paid-out costs in cash and kind - seed, fertiliser, hired labour, fuel, leased-in land rent.
- $A_2 + FL$ = A_2 plus the imputed value of unpaid family labour.
- C_2 = $A_2 + FL$ plus rent on owned land and imputed interest on owned fixed capital.
- So C_2 is always the largest of the three; an option saying A_2 exceeds C_2 is wrong on its face.

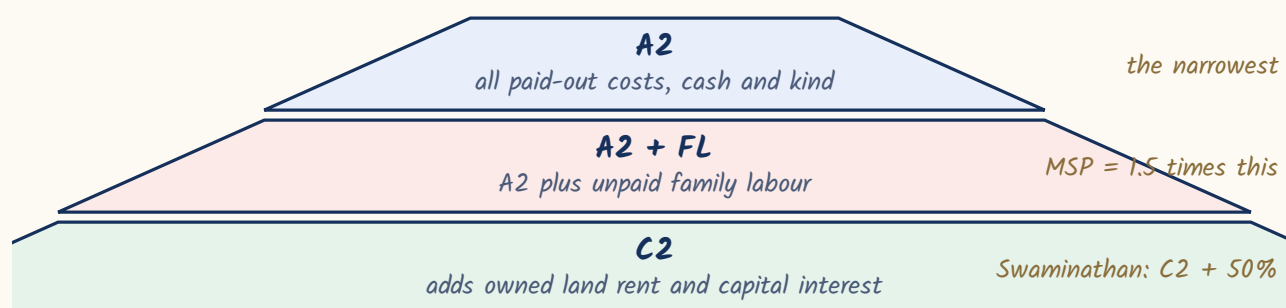
ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023, and a repeat topic - for how many crops is MSP announced? Answer: 22 mandated crops, made up of 14 kharif, 6 rabi and 2 commercial (copra and jute), with FRP for sugarcane counted separately. Learn the 14-6-2 split; that is the level of detail RPSC uses.

A₂+FL vs C₂ - the cost concept fight

A2+FL	C2
Paid-out costs plus imputed family labour	A2+FL plus rent on owned land and interest on owned capital
The narrower, lower cost measure	The comprehensive, higher cost measure
Budget 2018-19 fixed MSP at least 1.5 times A2+FL	The Swaminathan Commission recommended 50 per cent above C2
The basis the government uses in practice	The basis demanded by farmer organisations

The three cost concepts - each contains the one above



CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: for Kharif Marketing Season 2026-27 the CCEA approved MSP for 14 kharif crops in May 2026, raising paddy (common) by Rs 72 to Rs 2,441 per quintal. Note the exam pattern - the paddy common-grade figure is the one quoted in the news, so it is the one that gets asked.

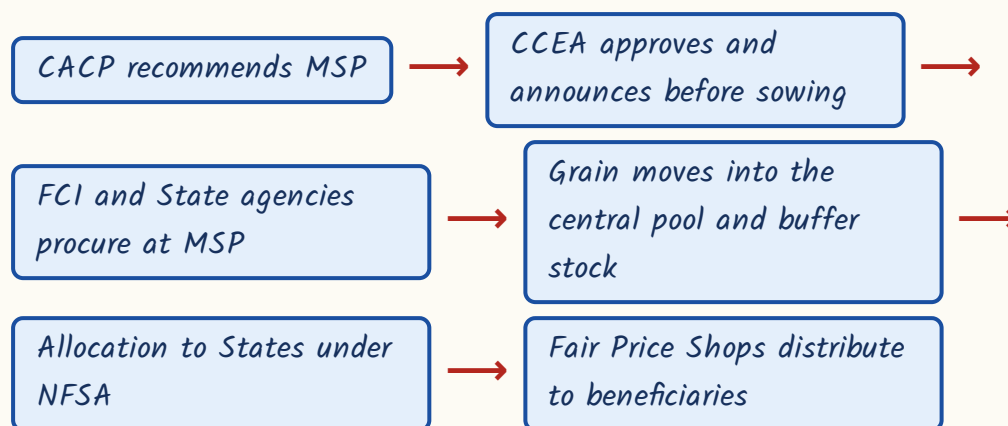
TRAP

CACP recommends, CCEA approves. If an option says the CACP 'fixes' or 'announces' MSP, it is wrong. And keep the asymmetry straight - MSP is not statutory, while sugarcane FRP is.

Procurement, PDS and the National Food Security Act

An announced price means nothing without a buyer. That buyer is the Food Corporation of India, set up in 1965 under the Food Corporations Act, 1964, together with the State agencies. FCI does three things - price support procurement, buffer stocking, and supply to the public distribution system. Since 1997-98 the Decentralised Procurement Scheme lets States procure, store and distribute on the Centre's behalf, which cuts transport cost. What is procured goes into the central pool, and out of the central pool comes the PDS.

From the field to the ration card



ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2018 - statements about the National Food Security Act, 2013. Learn the coverage exactly: up to 75 per cent of the rural population and up to 50 per cent of the urban population, which works out to about two-thirds of the country.

NFSA 2013 - the numbers that get asked

Item	Provision
Coverage	Up to 75 per cent rural, up to 50 per cent urban population
Priority households	5 kg of foodgrain per person per month

Item	Provision
Antyodaya Anna Yojana households	35 kg per household per month
Head of household for the ration card	The eldest woman aged 18 years or above
Maternity benefit	Rs 6,000 for pregnant women and lactating mothers
Grievance redress	District Grievance Redressal Officer and State Food Commission

TRAP

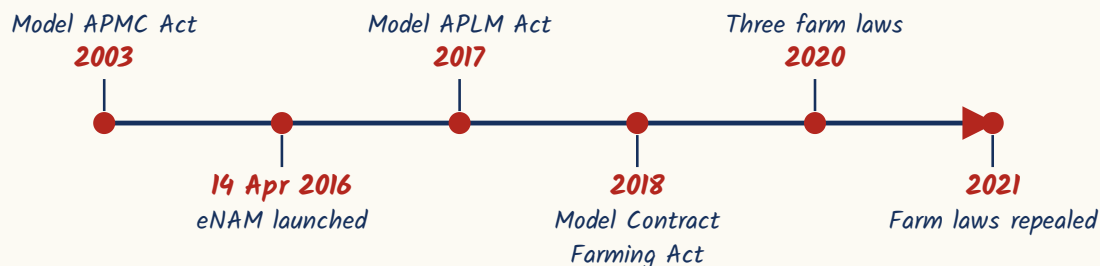
The 5 kg entitlement is PER PERSON per month for priority households; the 35 kg is PER HOUSEHOLD per month for Antyodaya households. Swapping the two is the standard distractor. And the woman-as-head rule needs her to be 18 or above, not 21.

Agricultural marketing - APMC, eNAM and the repealed farm laws

Agricultural marketing is a State subject. Each State passed an APMC Act requiring the farmer to sell in a notified market yard through licensed traders. The intention was to protect the farmer from the moneylender-trader; the result, over decades, was a closed market with few buyers and layers of commission. Every reform since has tried to open it up.

- Model APMC Act, 2003 - allowed private markets, direct purchase from farmers and contract farming; States adopted it patchily.
 - Model Agricultural Produce and Livestock Marketing (APLM) Act, 2017 - a fuller rewrite with a single State-wide licence and a unified market fee.
 - Model Contract Farming Act, 2018 - a separate law so that contract farming sits outside the APMC yard altogether.
 - eNAM was launched on 14 April 2016 and is implemented by the Small Farmers' Agribusiness Consortium.
 - eNAM is not a separate mandi - it is an electronic portal networking existing APMC mandis into one pan-India trading platform.
 - Gramin Agricultural Markets were meant to link village haats into the eNAM network.
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- Farm law 1 - Farmers' Produce Trade and Commerce (Promotion and Facilitation) Act, 2020: trade outside APMC yards, in notified 'trade areas'.
 - Farm law 2 - Farmers (Empowerment and Protection) Agreement on Price Assurance and Farm Services Act, 2020: a national framework for contract farming.
 - Farm law 3 - Essential Commodities (Amendment) Act, 2020: removed cereals, pulses, oilseeds, onion and potato from routine stock limits.
 - All three were repealed by the Farm Laws Repeal Act, 2021, after a year-long agitation.
 - The core objection was that trade outside the mandi would erode APMC revenue and, with it, the MSP-procurement system.

Marketing reform - the model-law ladder



YAAD RAKHO

Remember the model-law ladder: APMC 2003, APLM 2017, Contract Farming 2018, three farm laws 2020, repeal 2021. A clean chronological set - and RPSC likes chronology questions.

The scheme block - learn the year, the number and the launch place

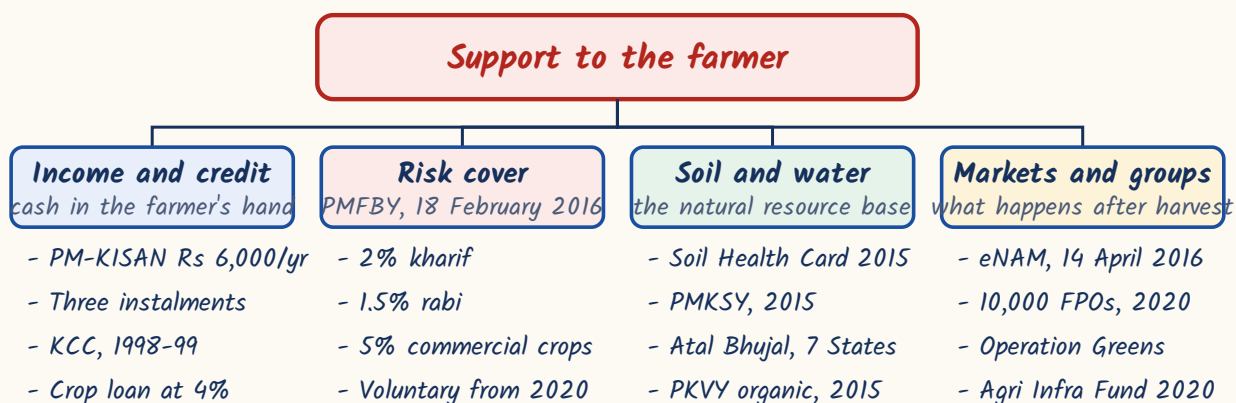
This is where most of the marks in this chapter actually sit. Each scheme carries one date, one number and sometimes one place. Learn those three; the descriptions look after themselves.

Farmer support schemes - the core table

Scheme	Launched	Key number or fact
PM-KISAN	Announced 1 Feb 2019, launched 24 Feb 2019, effective 1 Dec 2018	Rs 6,000 a year in three instalments of Rs 2,000; a Central Sector Scheme
PMFBY	18 February 2016	Farmer premium 2% kharif, 1.5% rabi, 5% commercial and horticultural

Scheme	Launched	Key number or fact
Soil Health Card	19 February 2015, at Suratgarh, Sri Ganganagar, Rajasthan	Reports 12 parameters including N, P, K, S, pH, EC and organic carbon
PMKSY	2015, extended for 2021-26	'Har Khet Ko Pani' and 'Per Drop More Crop'
Atal Bhujal Yojana	25 December 2019, Ministry of Jal Shakti	Rs 6,000 crore, half from the World Bank, 7 States
PKVY	2015	Cluster-based organic farming
10,000 FPOs scheme	29 February 2020, at Chitrakoot	SFAC, NCDC and NABARD are the implementing agencies

Farmer schemes grouped by what they deliver



ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 AND RAS Pre 2023 - Atal Bhujal Yojana. Learn it cold: launched 25 December 2019 by the Ministry of Jal Shakti, outlay Rs 6,000 crore shared equally between the Centre and the World Bank, community-led groundwater management in 7 States - Gujarat, Haryana, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh - covering about 8,350 water-stressed gram panchayats. Rajasthan is one of the seven, which is why RPSC keeps coming back to it.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 - under PM-KISAN, Rs 6,000 a year is paid in how many instalments? Answer: three equal instalments of Rs 2,000. It is a Central Sector Scheme, fully funded by the Centre, and income tax payers and institutional landholders are excluded.

- PMFBY replaced the National Agricultural Insurance Scheme and the Modified NAIS, and became voluntary for all farmers from kharif 2020.
- PMKSY's four components: AIBP, Har Khet Ko Pani, Per Drop More Crop, and Watershed Development.
- Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (2015) is the cluster-based organic farming scheme.
- Sikkim was declared India's first fully organic State in 2016 and won the FAO Future Policy Gold Award in 2018.
- The National Mission on Natural Farming (2024) builds on Subhash Palekar's zero budget natural farming.
- Organic certification: NPOP under APEDA for exports, and PGS-India for the domestic market.
- FPOs register either as Producer Companies under the Companies Act or as cooperative societies.

Food processing and post-harvest infrastructure

Programme	What it does
PM Kisan SAMPADA Yojana	Umbrella food processing scheme, Ministry of Food Processing Industries
PMFME	Micro food processing enterprises, on the One District One Product approach
Operation Greens	Price stabilisation for tomato, onion and potato
Agriculture Infrastructure Fund, 2020	Rs 1 lakh crore financing facility for post-harvest infrastructure

TRAP

Soil Health Card was launched at Suratgarh in Sri Ganganagar district of Rajasthan on 19 February 2015; PMFBY was launched on 18 February 2016. Two schemes, mid-February, consecutive years, one day apart. RPSC has every reason to swap them in a matching question.

Allied sectors, farm income and the newest scheme

Allied sectors - dairy, poultry, fisheries - now grow faster than crop agriculture and are the main route to higher incomes on small holdings. The Economic Survey has been saying so for several years. Learn India's world-ranking list, because it is asked as a statement-based question.

- India is the world's **LARGEST** producer of milk and of pulses.
- India is the **SECOND** largest producer of rice, wheat, sugarcane, fruits, vegetables, cotton and fish.
- Operation Flood, launched in 1970 under the NDDB, was led by Verghese Kurien - the White Revolution.
- Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana was launched in September 2020 with an outlay of about Rs 20,050 crore - the Blue Revolution's current vehicle.
- Rashtriya Gokul Mission, 2014, is for indigenous cattle breed development.

- The Committee on Doubling Farmers' Income was constituted in 2016 and chaired by Ashok Dalwai.
- It submitted a 14-volume report in September 2018.
- Base year 2015-16, target year 2022-23.
- Its sources of income growth: productivity gains, resource use efficiency, higher cropping intensity.
- Also diversification to high-value crops, better prices, cost reduction, and moving workers out of farming.
- Launch-year ladder for chronology questions: Soil Health Card and PKVY 2015, PMFBY and eNAM 2016, PM-KISAN 2019, Atal Bhujal December 2019, FPO scheme and PMMSY 2020, PM Dhan-Dhaanya 2025.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: PM Dhan-Dhaanya Krishi Yojana was approved by the Cabinet in July 2025 and announced in the Budget 2025-26. It targets 100 low-productivity districts, with an annual outlay of Rs 24,000 crore for six years, converging 36 existing schemes of 11 Ministries. It is modelled on the Aspirational Districts Programme and is the most likely new-scheme question for 2026.

REVISION RECAP

1. Four pillars of land reform: abolition of intermediaries, tenancy reform, ceiling, consolidation - in that order.
2. Bihar passed the first zamindari abolition law in 1950; the Kameshwar Singh case led to the First Amendment 1951 and the Ninth Schedule.
3. Operation Barga, West Bengal 1978, registered bargadars - the best tenancy reform. Consolidation succeeded in Punjab and Haryana.
4. Bhoodan - Vinoba Bhave, 18 April 1951, Pochampally. Gramdan - Mangroth, UP, 1952.
5. Agriculture Census 2015-16: average holding 1.08 ha; small and marginal 86.2 per cent of holdings, about 47 per cent of area.
6. Cropping intensity = $\frac{\text{gross cropped area}}{\text{net sown area}} \times 100$.

7. Green Revolution from 1966-67: wheat Lerma Rojo 64A and Sonora 64 (CIMMYT, Mexico), rice IR-8 (IRRI, Philippines).
8. IADP 1960-61 at Thanjavur with Ford Foundation aid; IAAP 1964-65; HYVP 1966-67. Swaminathan, and Borlaug's Nobel in 1970.
9. Colour codes: White milk (Operation Flood 1970, Kurien), Yellow oilseeds 1986, Blue fisheries, Golden horticulture, Grey fertilisers, Golden Fibre jute.
10. NABARD 12 July 1982, CRAFICARD under B. Sivaraman, HQ Mumbai. KCC 1998-99, R.V. Gupta Committee.
11. PSL: 40 per cent of ANBC overall, agriculture 18 per cent, 10 per cent for small and marginal farmers; crop loan effective 4 per cent on prompt repayment.
12. CACP set up January 1965 as the APC, renamed 1985, advisory only. CCEA approves MSP, and MSP is not legally enforceable.
13. MSP covers 22 crops - 14 kharif, 6 rabi, 2 commercial; sugarcane gets FRP under the Sugarcane (Control) Order 1966.
14. A2 is paid-out cost; A2+FL adds family labour; C2 adds rent on owned land and interest on owned capital. Budget 2018-19 promised 1.5 times A2+FL; Swaminathan wanted C2 plus 50 per cent.
15. FCI 1965 under the Food Corporations Act 1964; Decentralised Procurement since 1997-98.
16. NFSA 2013: 75 per cent rural, 50 per cent urban; priority 5 kg per person, AAY 35 kg per household; eldest woman 18+ is head; maternity benefit Rs 6,000.
17. eNAM 14 April 2016, run by SFAC, networks APMC mandis. Model Acts 2003, 2017, 2018. Three farm laws 2020, repealed 2021.
18. PM-KISAN Rs 6,000 in three instalments, a Central Sector Scheme, effective 1 December 2018.
19. PMFBY 18 February 2016 - premium 2 per cent kharif, 1.5 per cent rabi, 5 per cent commercial; voluntary from kharif 2020.
20. Soil Health Card 19 February 2015 at Suratgarh, Rajasthan, 12 parameters; Atal Bhujal 25 December 2019, Rs 6,000 crore, 7 States including Rajasthan, about 8,350 gram panchayats.